M3 Discussion | Ethics in AI: Facial Recognition

Patrick Hall, AAI101 Introduction to AI, DMACC, Fall 2026

Note: compiled for this portfolio from the saved post text (M3_Ethics_WordCloud_Text.txt) and the word cloud image (M3_Ethics_WordCloud.png). The text is reproduced unchanged.

Facial recognition is an AI application that identifies or verifies people by analyzing facial features in photos or video. It is already used in airports for identity checks, on phones for unlocking devices, and by some organizations for security and surveillance.

Using an AI Ethics Canvas style analysis, the main benefits include faster identity verification, improved security, and convenience for travelers and users. The risks include privacy loss, biased error rates across demographic groups, wrongful identification, and mass surveillance without clear consent. Key stakeholders include the people being scanned, companies that build the systems, organizations that deploy them, law enforcement, regulators, and the broader public.

The three dimensions of AI ethics I am comparing are Fairness, Accountability, and Transparency. Fairness asks whether the system treats different groups equally and avoids discriminatory outcomes. Accountability asks who is responsible when the system makes a harmful mistake. Transparency asks whether people know the system is being used and can understand how decisions are made. Fairness focuses on equal treatment, accountability focuses on responsibility after harm, and transparency focuses on openness and explainability. They work together, but they are not the same.

For facial recognition, Fairness is the most relevant dimension because research has shown higher error rates for some racial and gender groups, which can lead to unequal harm such as false matches or wrongful suspicion. Accountability still matters for who owns the error, and Transparency matters for notice and consent, but biased performance is especially central to this technology.

One safeguard is requiring independent bias testing and human review before high-stakes use, plus clear policies that limit retention of biometric data and give people a way to challenge incorrect matches. That would reduce ethical concerns around unfair outcomes and misuse.

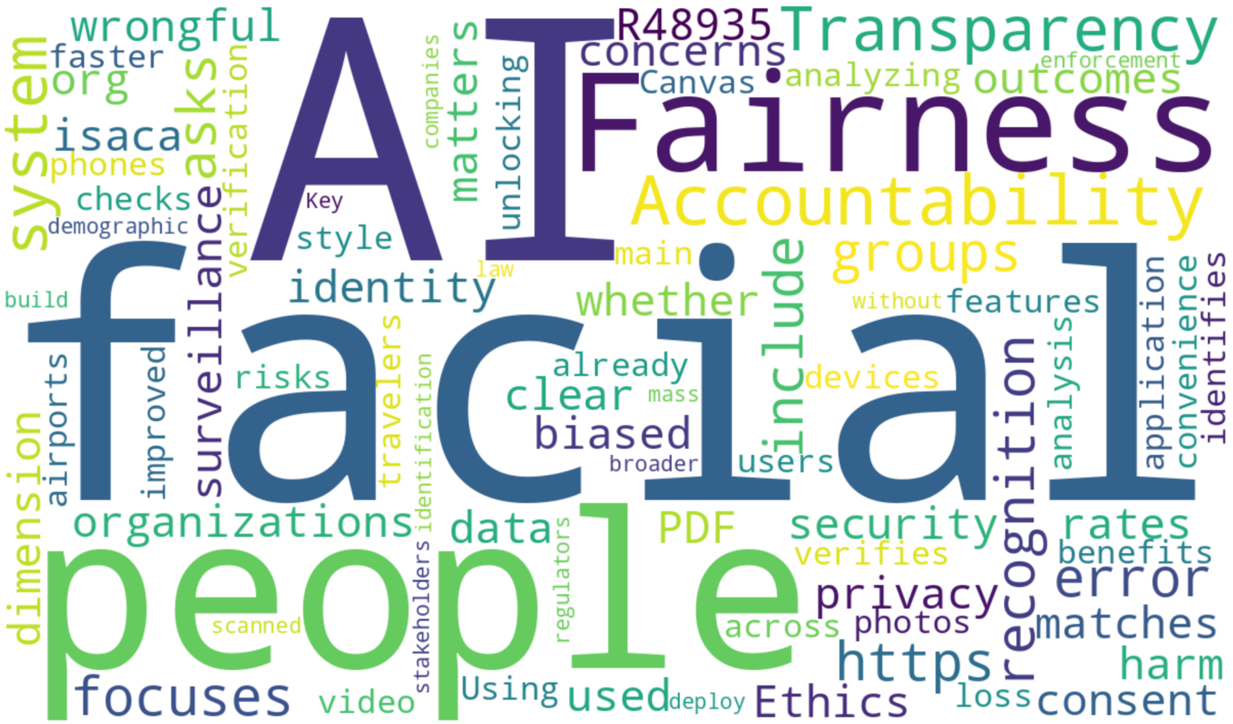
Sources:

https://www.congress.gov/crs_external_products/R/PDF/R48935/R48935.2.pdf

https://www.frontiersin.org/journals/big-data/articles/10.3389/fdata.2024.1337465/full

https://www.isaca.org/resources/news-and-trends/isaca-now-blog/2025/facial-recognition-and-privacy-concerns-and-solutions-in-the-age-of-ai

Word cloud



AI
Fairness
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Transparency
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https
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focuses
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